from just such foundation myths, and so it has been in India. But, to my mind, it has come at a price. Firstly, it was necessary to present what had gone before as a period of unmitigated oppression, and the Indian peoples as having been united against that oppression. The papering over of any cracks that challenged this simplistic view of the past or threatened the social cohesion of the present achieved its apotheosis in 1982 when India's National Council for Educational Research and Training issued a directive requiring school texts to gloss over sensitive issues such as sectarian conflict, declaring categorically, for example, that 'Characterisation of the medieval period as a dark period or as a time of conflict between Hindus and Muslims is forbidden'. This well-intentioned but misguided instruction played directly into the hands of the Hindutvatistas – by which I mean those disciples of Savarkar, Golwalkar and the RSS and all its offshoots – who saw it as proof of a Marxist-Muslim-Imperialist plot directed against their Hindu India.

A second consequence of this quasi-sanctification of the Freedom Struggle is that it was done to the near exclusion of much else. I would not for one minute wish to downplay what was by any standard an epic and glorious chapter in India's history, achieved through much personal sacrifice, but it is just that: a chapter. And like all chapters in India's history it deserves to be examined as scrupulously as other chapters and not set above all else. The effect has been to stifle historical inquiry, resulting in what strikes me as widespread ignorance about India's real as opposed to its imagined past – and perhaps even a preference for that imaginary India over the real, living one.

Ignorance of the past is what has allowed the revisionism that Golwalkar and his colleagues in the Hindutva movement initiated almost a century ago to re-enter the public consciousness, thanks to more recent proponents of Hindutva history such as the late Sita Ram Goel, a former Marxist turned publisher and polemicist. Goel argued that